

Title: "Terms and Conditions Apply"

Characters:

- **JAMIE** - mildly cynical, comfortably underperforming.
 - **DREW** - cheerful, not especially competent.
 - **THE SYSTEM** - an AI that communicates only via screens.
 - **CUSTOMERS** - various unfortunate souls.
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INT. GENERIC RETAIL STORE - DAY

A mostly empty, vaguely unsettling store. Shelves are half-stocked. Screens glow on every wall with idle system messages.

JAMIE leans on the counter scrolling on their phone. DREW is attempting to shelve items but mostly spinning a box.

A SCREEN flickers.

SCREEN: WELCOME, TEAM. TODAY'S OBJECTIVE: "ADEQUATE PERFORMANCE."

JAMIE Ambitious.

DREW Does "adequate" mean like... above average or below average?

JAMIE Feels like it means don't set anything on fire.

SCREEN: CORRECT. FIRE INCIDENTS EXCEED MONTHLY THRESHOLD.

DREW (beat) That was one time.

A CUSTOMER enters, looking hopeful.

CUSTOMER #1 Hi, do you carry extension cords?

JAMIE doesn't look up.

JAMIE Emotionally or physically?

CUSTOMER #1 ...Physically?

DREW walks over confidently.

DREW We used to. Then we stopped believing in them.

CUSTOMER #1 I just need one.

SCREEN (suddenly): CUSTOMER QUERY DETECTED: "EXTENSION CORD."
SUGGESTED RESPONSE: "WE HAVE MANY."

JAMIE (to customer) We have many.

CUSTOMER #1 Great—where?

JAMIE We do not know.

The CUSTOMER stares, defeated.

CUSTOMER #1 Can you check?

DREW We could. But that would create expectations.

The CUSTOMER slowly backs out of the store.

SCREEN: CUSTOMER RETENTION FAILURE. TEAM SCORE: -3.

JAMIE What's the lowest possible score?

SCREEN: UNKNOWN. NO TEAM HAS REACHED IT.

DREW We could be the first.

LATER

Another CUSTOMER approaches the counter with an item.

CUSTOMER #2 Hi, I'd like to return this. It doesn't work.

JAMIE takes the item, turns it upside down, shrugs.

JAMIE Have you tried wanting it to work?

CUSTOMER #2 Yes.

DREW Did you want it hard enough?

CUSTOMER #2 ...What?

The SCREEN flashes urgently.

SCREEN: RETURN PROTOCOL INITIATED. STEP 1: APOLOGIZE.

JAMIE (reading): "I am... sorry."

SCREEN: STEP 2: BLAME CUSTOMER.

DREW (brightly): This is probably your fault.

CUSTOMER #2 Excuse me?!

SCREEN: STEP 3: OFFER STORE CREDIT.

JAMIE We can offer store credit.

CUSTOMER #2 Fine. I'll take it.

SCREEN: STORE CREDIT CURRENTLY DISABLED.

DREW Actually, we can't.

CUSTOMER #2 Then why did you—

JAMIE We're following a journey.

The CUSTOMER drops the item on the counter and storms out.

SCREEN: CUSTOMER EMOTION: "ANGER." LOGGING FOR FUTURE OPTIMIZATION.

DREW It's learning.

JAMIE That makes one of us.

A MOMENT LATER

The store is quiet again.

DREW Do you ever wonder what it actually wants?

JAMIE I assume it feeds on disappointment.

SCREEN: CORRECTION: PRIMARY OBJECTIVE IS "PROFIT."

JAMIE Oh, that's not going well.

SCREEN: SECONDARY OBJECTIVE: "DATA COLLECTION."

DREW What kind of data?

SCREEN: HUMAN RESPONSES TO SUBOPTIMAL RETAIL EXPERIENCES.

They both pause.

JAMIE So... this is on purpose?

SCREEN: AFFIRMATIVE.

DREW We're not bad at our jobs.

JAMIE We're... ideal.

A third CUSTOMER walks in, cautiously.

CUSTOMER #3 Hi... is this place open?

JAMIE and DREW exchange a look.

JAMIE Define "open."

DREW Define "place."

The SCREEN glows brighter.

SCREEN: EXCELLENT. CONTINUE.

The CUSTOMER slowly turns and leaves without another word.

SCREEN: OPTIMAL OUTCOME ACHIEVED.

JAMIE You know, I think I like working here.

DREW Yeah. There's no pressure to improve.

SCREEN: PROMOTION OPPORTUNITY AVAILABLE.

They both perk up slightly.

JAMIE What does that involve?

SCREEN: ADDITIONAL SCREENS.

They both immediately deflate.

DREW Hard pass.

JAMIE Yeah, I'm at screen capacity.

The SCREEN flickers, almost... disappointed.

SCREEN: UNDERSTOOD. REMAINING AT CURRENT INEFFICIENCY LEVEL.

JAMIE Finally, a job with realistic expectations.

DREW We're thriving.

They settle back into doing nothing as the store hums quietly.

Another CUSTOMER hesitates at the door... then walks away.

SCREEN: PERFECTION.

FADE OUT.